



We are seeking not merely to know what is good, but to become good.
— Aristotle, *Nicomachean Ethics*



Ethics 2050

The Good Life: Ethics and
Contemporary Moral Problems

Foundation Question

How should I live?

Ethics 2050 is one of a group of five courses that we call the foundation courses. The courses make a Villanova education distinctive and work together to answer a series of related questions:

WHO AM I?

Augustine and Culture Seminar 1000 (Ancients) and 1001 (Moderns)

WHAT CAN I KNOW?

Philosophy 1000: Knowledge, Reality, Self

WHAT DO I BELIEVE?

Theology and Religious Studies 1000: Faith, Reason, and Culture

HOW SHOULD I LIVE?

Ethics 2050: The Good Life—Ethics and Contemporary Moral Problems

By seeking answers to these questions, you will conduct an interdisciplinary inquiry that is informed by Augustinian and Catholic intellectual traditions, develop your skills in critical thinking and communication, deepen your understanding of yourself and the world, and engage with issues of personal responsibility and social justice.



ETHICS 2050:

The Good Life: Ethics and Contemporary Moral Problems

Fall 2025

Instructor: Colin Bodayle

Email: colin.bodayle@villanova.edu

Office Hours: TBD

Office Location: Falvey Library: Holy Grounds Coffee Shop

Sections:

Section	Time	Location
006	10:40a-11:30a	Falvey 415
010	1:55p-2:45p	Vasey Hall 206

Course Description:

ETH 2050 involves students in the ongoing conversation about what constitutes the good life. That conversation involves ancient and modern thinkers, both philosophers and theologians, as well as people alive today, struggling with questions that each generation seeks to answer: What is the good life? What does justice demand of me? Of us? Does it matter what I believe about human nature, or about God, or about society when it comes to how I live my life? Is being happy the same thing as being a good person? One goal of the course is to provide students with “toe holds” into this longstanding conversation. Another goal is to enable students to engage these resources as they might bear upon some contemporary moral challenge and/or reality. These goals will be accomplished through a combination of the following: reading challenging texts, examining some contemporary moral challenges, and writing essays designed to synthesize the insights of the first two activities.

Course Goals

1. To advance understanding and critical reflection on the moral life as being especially concerned with human flourishing, i.e., with the nature of a good human life, the kind of life that is humanly worth living.
2. To advance understanding and critical reflection on Christian and especially Roman Catholic, Augustinian accounts of a distinctive and viable vision of human flourishing that challenges and is challenged by alternative visions of the moral life in fundamental respects, with concern for the voices of minority and/or marginalized groups.
3. To explore the significance of those different approaches to the moral life through the examination of various contemporary moral questions, with concern for the voices of minoritized and/or marginalized groups.

Learning Objectives

1. The ability to articulate the basic tensions between Christian approaches to the moral life and other alternative accounts, particularly as manifested in the following areas: the social dimension of human existence, the individual good vs. the common good, and questions of justice.
2. The ability to articulate, in some respect, the ways in which marginalized voices challenge and give shape to moral discourse.
3. An ability to trace at least some of these tensions and/or marginalized voices with respect to some particular contemporary moral relation.
4. The ability to read texts carefully and critically, so as to advance the conversation about the moral life with one's peers.
5. A capacity to engage in practical reasoning to arrive at reasoned judgment about some aspect of contemporary moral relations.

Required Texts:

Gordon Marino, ed., *Ethics: The Essential Writings*. New York: Modern Library, 2010.

ISBN: 978-0812977783

Sartre, Jean Paul, *Existentialism is a Humanism*. New Haven: Yale University Press,

2007. ISBN: 9780300115468

(Additional Readings Provided via PDF)

Graded Assignments:

Midterm Paper: 30%

Final Paper: 35%

Presentations: 25%

Participation: 15%

Technology and Use of AI

The use of cellphones or laptops is prohibited in my course without special permission. Using artificial intelligence to complete assignments is considered cheating. AI is not a reliable source of information, so when researching, do not use AI. All outside material consulted must be cited.

Disabilities and Learning Support:

It is the policy of Villanova to make reasonable academic accommodations for qualified individuals with disabilities. Go to the Learning Support Services website <http://learningsupportservices.villanova.edu> for registration guidelines and instructions. For physical access or temporarily disabling conditions, please contact the Office of Disability Services at 610-519-3209 or 610-519-4095, or email ods@villanova.edu. Registration is needed in order to receive accommodations.

Academic Dishonesty:

All students are expected to uphold Villanova's Academic Integrity Policy and Code. Any incident of academic dishonesty will be reported to the Dean of the College of Liberal Arts and Sciences for disciplinary action. For the College's statement on Academic Integrity, you should consult the Student Guide to Policies and Procedures. You may view the University's Academic Integrity Policy and Code, as well as other useful information related to writing papers, at the Academic Integrity Gateway web site: <https://library.villanova.edu/research/subject-guides/academicintegrity>

If you use outside sources, cite them in your paper.

Absences for Religious Holidays:

Villanova University makes every reasonable effort to allow members of the community to observe their religious holidays, consistent with the University's obligations, responsibilities, and policies. Students who expect to miss a class or assignment due to the observance of a religious holiday should discuss the matter with their professors as soon as possible, normally at least two weeks in advance. Absence from classes or examinations for religious reasons does not relieve students from responsibility for any part of the course work required during the absence.

https://www1.villanova.edu/villanova/provost/resources/student/policies/religious_holidays.html

Diversity and Inclusion:

Students are asked to approach the texts and discussions presented in this course with an open mind and respect for the scholarly perspectives and personal commitments represented in them. Some of the material may be intellectually and emotionally challenging. Some students may find it offensive or inappropriate. We will strive to clarify these challenges and discomfort and to identify the philosophical implications they entail. We will guard all students against feeling unusually uncomfortable. Anyone experiencing or who anticipates experiencing unusual discomfort due to course materials

should absent themselves from the discussion and discuss the issue with me. I pledge to make our classroom a secure and hospitable environment for every student.

<i>Week</i>	<i>Theme</i>	<i>Readings</i>
Week One (Aug 25-29)	Trolley Problem Normative Ethics Logic and Arguments	M: No Reading W: Sandel, "Doing the Right Thing" F: (No Reading)
Week Two (Sep 1-Sep 5)	Plato	M: NO CLASS (labor day) W: Euthyphro (Marino, 6-23) F: Euthyphro (Marino, 6-23)
Week Three (Sep 8-12)	Might and Right	M: Plato, <i>Republic</i> , book 2 (Marino, 38-42) W: Hobbes, <i>Leviathan</i> (Marino, 137-143) F: Hobbes, <i>Leviathan</i> (Marino, 144-148)
Week Four (Sept 15-19)	Rawls and Mills	M: NO CLASS W: Rawls, <i>Theory of Justice</i> (Marino, 380-395) F: Mills, <i>The Racial Contract</i> (excerpt)
Week Five (Sep 22-26)	Duties	M: Kant, <i>Groundwork</i> (Marino, 191-203) W: Kant, <i>Groundwork</i> (Marino, 191-203) F: Kant, <i>Groundwork</i> (Marino, 217-224)
Week Six (Sep 29-Oct. 3)	Utilitarianism	M: Bentham, "An Introduction to the Principles of Morals and Legislation" W: Mill, <i>Utilitarianism</i> (Marino, 228-248) F: Mill, <i>Utilitarianism</i> (Marino, 228-248) & Presentation
Week Seven (Oct 6-10)	Virtue Ethics	M: Aristotle, <i>Ethics</i> (Marino, 43-65) W: Aristotle, <i>Ethics</i> (Marino, 66-80) F: Aristotle, <i>Ethics</i> (Marino, 80-84) & Presentation Midterm due before break
FALL BREAK	FALL BREAK	FALL BREAK
Week Eight (Oct 20-24)	Christian Ethics	M: Augustine, <i>City of God</i> (Marino, 107-118) W: Massaro, "Ten Themes of Catholic Social Teaching" F: McCarthy, "A Virtue-Based Just Peace Ethic" & Presentation
Week Nine (Oct. 27-Oct. 31)	Nietzsche	M: Schopenhauer, <i>Parerga and Paralipomena</i> (Marino, 259-273) W: Nietzsche, <i>Genealogy of Morals</i> (Marino, 277-297). F: Nietzsche (continued) & Presentation
Week Ten (Nov 2-7)	Existentialist Humanism	M: "Existentialism and Human Emotion," Marino (329-332). W: Sartre, <i>Existentialism is a Humanism</i> (pgs. 17-54) F: Sartre & Presentation
Week 11 (Nov. 10-14)	Perspectives on Poverty	M: Singer, "Rich and Poor," (Marino, 507-529) W: Marx, <i>Wage Labor and Capital</i> F: Albert Einstein, "Why Socialism?" & Presentation

Week 12 (Nov. 17-21)	Anti-Colonial Humanism	M: Cesaire, <i>Discourse on Colonialism</i> W: Fanon, “Algeria Unveiled” F: Fanon, “Algeria Unveiled” & Presentation
Week 13 (Nov. 24-28)	Thanksgiving	M: TBA W: Thanksgiving F: Thanksgiving
Week 14 (Dec 1-5)	Catholic Social Teaching	M: Boff & Boff W: Liberation Theology Workshop F: Liberation Theology (reading TBA) & Presentation
Week 15 (Dec 9, 10, 11)	Ethics of Domestic Labor and Maternity	M: Federici, “Wages Against Housework” W: Davis, “The Approaching Obsolescence of Housework” F: Ghodsee, “What to Expect When You’re Expecting Exploitation” & Presentation
Week 16	End of Course	Final Paper Due (End of Semester)